

UMMER

the forthcoming action movie *Tashan*. Sajid Nadiadwala, one of Bollywood's old style producers who works with friends and is fondly called *Sajidbhai* even by those not related to him, says heroines are cast in consultation with the director and keeping in mind their compatibility with the male co-star. In Bollywood's male-dominated world, one false move can still veto a big film for a woman. Ask Aishwarya Rai Bachchan.

Yet, as professional as these new women are, they are also pragmatic. "They all want to work with big male

stars because they all want to be commercially successful," says Ali. As Basu, 29, who plays a svelte model in *Race*, puts it: "If I am able to reach out to more people through my mainstream movies, I am also able to create an additional audience for my more experimental work, whether it be *Corporate* or the forthcoming *Pankh*." So even as heroes have "way too much money being thrown at them," she says, "it's a fact that audiences still decide to watch

BIPASHA BASU, 29: She makes upwards of Rs 1.5 crore per film



a film based on its hero. But the women are also a big plus."

So in the general inflation of industry rates, even the heroines have benefited. Navin Shah of marketing agency P9 says: "The higher prices the girls are charging is a function of the scarcity of talent. Assembling a project requires at least one smart girl. Even if producers can afford the top female stars, they don't have dates." The A-list women earn as much as a lot of men immediately below the top clique of the four Khans, Akshay Kumar and Hrithik Roshan, who all charge in multiples of Rs 10 crore, especially given their additional income from endorsements, personal appearances and concerts. It doesn't hurt that most of these women have interesting love lives, involving excitable boyfriends, which ensures

KATRINA KAIF, 24: Has signed a two film deal for Rs 6 crore with Studio 18